



Offa's Dyke, which roughly follows the line of the Welsh–English border, was constructed during the reign of Offa of Mercia; stretches are still visible today.

sent his armies across the Pyrenees but they **failed to take the city of Saragossa** (modern-day Zaragoza in Spain) and were forced to retreat.

This botched expedition inadvertently launched one of the great romances of medieval times, the **legend of Roland**. In 778, Roland, one of Charlemagne's generals, was killed during an attack on the rearguard of the Carolingian armies as they retreated through the Pyrenean valley of **Roncesvalles**. The attack was actually carried out by Basques, but Roland's Breton followers took up the tale and as it spread through France in the following centuries it morphed into a legend with many fictitious elements: Roland became the nephew of an elderly, white-bearded Charlemagne; his attackers the perfidious Saracens; and Roland was Count of the Marches of Brittany. By the 11th century, the **"Song of Roland"** appeared as an early *chanson de geste*; a heroic epic of the age of chivalry.

In Constantinople, the **death of Emperor Leo IV** brought to the throne his infant son, **Constantine VI**. During his minority the empire was under the regency of the **Empress Irene**, his mother.

CHARLEMAGNE'S CONQUEST OF WEST SAXONY in 782 comprised a bloody development with the mass execution of 4,500 Saxon prisoners at Werden. This event was appropriated by Nazi

historians in the 1930s as a sort of pre-Christian Germanic martyrdom, while others have called into question its details and even occurrence. Meanwhile, concerned about ignorance and illiteracy among the clergy, Charlemagne launched a Carolingian cultural renaissance.

In 786, **Haroun al-Rashid** (r. 786–809) acceded to the caliphate in Baghdad. Under his rule the Barmakid family gained great power as his viziers (high-ranking advisors) and favorites, while the **intellectual and cultural flowering of the Islamic world** gathered pace. Growing enthusiasm among the rich and powerful for books encouraged scholars to begin translating ancient Greek and Roman texts into Arabic.

In 785, Offa of Mercia (r. 757–96), effective overlord of Britain, started constructing the monumental earthwork known as Offa's Dyke, on the border between Wales and Mercia. Originally 89ft (27m) wide and 26ft (8m) high, the purpose of the dyke is unknown, and it probably fell into disuse soon after its completion.



Imperial gift
An exquisite water pitcher sent to Charlemagne by Haroun al-Rashid, probably c. 800.



The giant Buddha at Leshan in China was begun in 713 and finished 90 years later.

VIKING RAIDS on the shores of the British Isles started in 789 and gathered pace in the 790s with the looting of the rich monasteries of Lindisfarne and Iona. The "Vikings" (possibly from the Old Norse language) originated in Scandinavia.

In Tang China, the **influence of Buddhism continued to grow**, signaled by monuments such as the **Leshan Buddha**, a giant statue of the seated Buddha carved into a bluff next to the confluence of several major rivers.

In Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul), the emperor invited his **mother Irene to become co-ruler** in 792; four years later she had him blinded and declared herself empress. This move spurred the scholar Alcuin of York to suggest that the imperial seat was effectively vacant, and on December 25, 800, **Charlemagne was crowned Emperor of the Romans** by his ally, Pope Leo III. In the same year he received an embassy from Haroun al-Rashid, emblematic of how the focus of power in Europe had shifted. In 800, the Abbasid caliphs in Baghdad were forced to recognize



Functional and stylish brooch
Skillfully crafted out of gold, this Viking brooch was not only beautiful but also practical, used to fasten cloaks or other clothing.

more or less **complete loss of authority in Africa west of Egypt**. They conceded to the emir of the province of Ifriqiya (modern-day Tunisia and part of Algeria) the right to make his post hereditary. The emir, Ibrahim ibn Aghlab, thus **founded the Aghlabid Dynasty**. This paid tribute to Baghdad and nominally recognized Abbasid authority, but ruled much of North Africa as an independent state.

"[CHARLEMAGNE] WAS LARGE AND STRONG AND OF LOFTY STATURE, THOUGH NOT DISPROPORTIONATELY TALL."

Einhard, Charlemagne's friend and Frankish historian, c. 830

778 Failed Carolingian expedition to Spain, **Siege of Saragossa**
778 Battle of **Roncesvalles**
780 Byzantine regency of **Irene**
781 Nestorian Christians in China erect **Nestorian Tablet** in Chang'an

781 Carolingian Renaissance begins
782 Charlemagne conquers **West Saxony**
786 Haroun al-Rashid becomes caliph; ascendancy of **Barmakids**
785 Construction of **Offa's Dyke** begins
787 Council of Nicaea ends **iconoclasm** controversy
c. 788 **Moroccan Shiite** revolt under **Idris**
789 First **Viking attack** in Britain
790 Army mutinies in Constantinople depose **Irene**, and puts **Constantine VI** in charge

792 Byzantine emperor **Constantine VI** makes his **mother Irene** co-ruler
793 Vikings sack **Lindisfarne**
794 Japanese capital moves to **Kyoto**
796 **Offa of Mercia** dies (b. 730)
797 **Irene** has **Constantine** blinded and declares herself empress once more
795 Vikings raid **Ireland**
796 Charlemagne battles **Avars**, loots **Avar hoard**
800 Charlemagne crowned **Emperor of the Romans**
800 **Zen Buddhism** preeminent in China
800 **Aghlabid dynasty** (800–909) established in Tunisia, Algeria, and Sicily